

First Hong Kong Linguistics Olympiad
24 March 2019
Individual Contest Problems

Rules for writing out the solutions

Do not copy the statements of the problems. Write down your solution to each problem on the answer booklet. Your answers must be well-supported by argument. Even a perfectly correct answer will be given a low score unless accompanied by an explanation.

Problem 1 (15 points). Taiwanese Southern-Min

Taiwanese Southern-Min is a Sinitic tonal language with 7 tones. Historically, due to the 50 years of Japanese occupation that ended with World War II, many loan words are borrowed through Japanese, but originally from (mostly) English. This means that many of Japanese language's constraints on loan words are also adopted by Taiwanese. The following is a selected list of Taiwanese loan words and their English (French in one example) origin, without showing their Japanese pivot. Note that the numerical subscripts are tone makers, with 1 being the highest and 5 being the lowest. Hence 51 means high falling, 33 means mid-level, while a single 3 means that the duration is short; etc.

Taiwanese Southern-Min	English/French
ba₅₅ tah₃	butter
bat₃ te₅₅ lih₃	battery
bi₅₁ lu₁₁	beer
ha₅₅ muh₃	ham
khe₃₃ tsiap₅ puh₃	ketchup
sap₅-bûn₃₅	savon
se₃₃ bi₅₅ looh₃	Savile Row
oo₃₃ too₅₅ bai₅₁	auto-bike
uai₃₅ siat₅ tsuh₃	white shirt

(1) The following are 15 Taiwanese loan words, please give their English correspondents:

1. a₃₃ lu₅₅ mih₃
2. a₃₃ moo₅₅ ni₅₅a₅₁
3. a₃₃ sir₅₅ phi₅₅lin₅₁
4. ai₅₅ sirh₃ khu₃₃lin₅₁ mu₁₁
5. au₅₁ tsuh₃
6. kha₃₃ la₅₅ oo₅₅khe₅₅
7. kha₃₃ me₅₅ lah₃
8. kha₃₃ ta₅₅ lok₅guh₃
9. kha₃₃ tian₅₁
10. khi₅₅ looh₃

- 11. khok₅ puh₃
- 12. khong₁₁ ku₃₃ li₅₁
- 13. khoo₃₃ le₅₅ lah₃
- 14. khoo₃₃ mi₅₅siong₅₁
- 15. khoo₅₁ too₁₁

- (2) What is your observation of the constraints on words borrowed into Taiwanese through Japanese?
- (3) There are only a few syllables with short (‘abrupt’) duration. Can you find any common features among them?